Perceived Family Support Negatively Correlates with PTSD Symptomology Among 9/11 Responders

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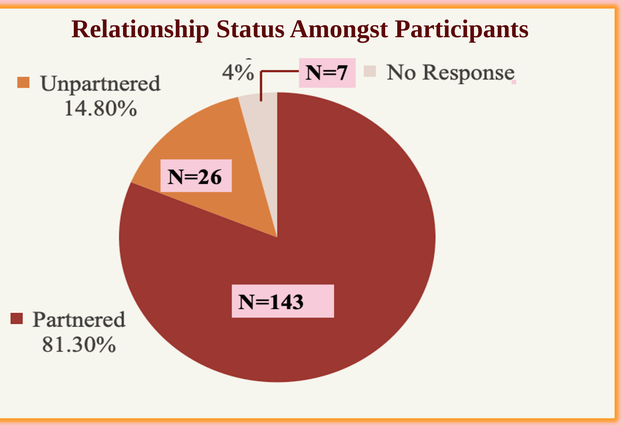
Introduction

- Social Support is defined as a deliberate attempt to exhibit support for an individual and can further be explored through the modality of support and nature of an individual's social network/ relationships. [1]
- Former research on the relationship between social support and PTSD severity has yielded:
  - Less severe avoidance, arousal, and intrusion symptoms for those reporting greater support. [2]
  - Heightened levels of perceived support from romantic partners negatively associated with overall PTSD severity. [3]
  - A positive correlation between partner involved therapeutic interventions and improvements in PTSD symptoms. [4, 5]

Aims

- To increase clarity on which relationships might be of particular importance to improved PTSD outcomes (e.g.: greater wellbeing, lower stress, and lower PTSD severity)
- Gain a deeper understanding of the connection between social support and the mitigation of PTSD symptomology.

Demographics

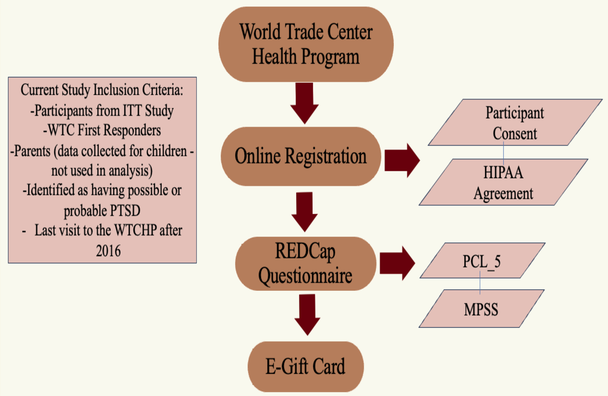


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Methodology

Study Design/ Measures



- Multidimensional Scale of Perceived Social Support (MPSS) [6]
- Posttraumatic Stress Disorder Checklist (PCL-5) [7]

Analysis

Responses to the MPSS were reverse coded and averaged to generate a score for the perceived level of social support from family, romantic partners, and friends.

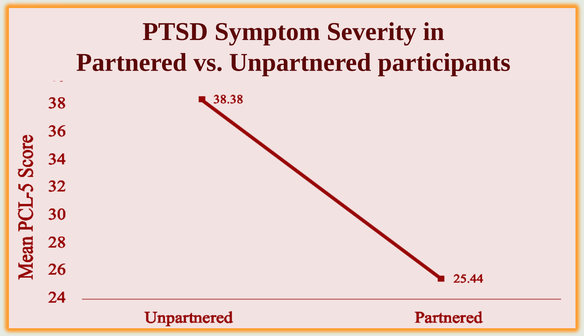
1st Analysis: One-Way ANOVA
IV: Partnered Participants vs. Unpartnered Participants
DV: PTSD Symptom Severity

2nd Analysis: Multiple Linear Regression
IVs (3 Variables): Perceived Level of Social Support from Family vs. Friends vs. Partners
DV: PTSD Symptom Severity

3rd Analysis: Multiple Linear Regression
IVs (3 Variables): Perceived Level of Social Support from Family vs. Friends vs. Partners
DV: Intrusive Thoughts, Avoidance, Negative Cognitive and Mood Changes, Arousal and Reactivity Symptom Scores

Results

1st Analysis



2nd Analysis

Table 1: Perceived Social Support and PTSD Symptomology

	Correlation Coefficient	Significance
Family	.341	**.000**
Partners	.267	**.002**
Friends	.267	**.002**

Table 2: Perceived Social Support and PTSD Symptomology

	Partial Correlation Coefficient	Correlation (Significance Level)
Family	.182	**.047**
Partners	.104	.259
Friends	.070	.448

3rd Analysis

Table 3: Perceived Social Support and Intrusive Thoughts

	Partial Correlation Coefficient	Correlation (Significance Level)
Family	.040	.673
Partners	.179	.055
Friends	.026	.779

Table 4: Perceived Social Support and Avoidance Symptoms

	Partial Correlation Coefficient	Correlation (Significance Level)
Family	.148	.112
Partners	.052	.582
Friends	.070	.458

Table 5: Perceived Social Support and Negative Cognitive and Mood Changes

	Partial Correlation Coefficient	Correlation (Significance Level)
Family	.216	**.022**
Partners	.041	.670
Friends	.064	.500

Table 6: Perceived Social Support and Arousal and Reactivity Symptoms

	Partial Correlation Coefficient	Correlation (Significance Level)
Family	.109	.252
Partners	.145	.127
Friends	.004	.970

Main Findings/ Conclusion

- Having a partner served as a protective factor for PTSD, as evidenced by lower symptomology
- Overall social support was negatively associated with each individual symptoms cluster
- Increased family support was associated with lower overall PTSD symptomology
- Partner support approached significance in predicting less intrusive symptoms
- Family support was most likely to influence reported negative cognition and mood changes

Limitations

- Assessment of social constructs, such as social support, are subject to participant interpretation.
- Findings may not be generalizable to other populations; women, recipients of long-term or complex trauma, younger age cohorts

Future Directions

- Further understanding may be obtained through immediate assessment of social supports following exposure to trauma
- Exploration of the potential impact of family-involved treatment interventions amongst trauma survivors (e.g.: treatment retention, treatment outcomes, resilience factors, etc.)
- Utilization of additional measures specific to social support by relationship type may contribute to a more comprehensive assessment of social support

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